out of 10 Test series and triumphed in eight out of 11 one-day international series.

That's a decent record. We were a decent side, a talented team that prided itself, above all, on being intensely competitive, on fighting for every wicket and scrapping for every run. It didn't matter whether we were playing at home or in front of hostile crowds on tour on the subcontinent or in Australia, we wanted to be known as the national side that never gave up, that trained the hardest and played the hardest, on and off the field.

Our team was built around three mighty pillars, three of the greatest cricketers ever to play for South Africa: Graeme Smith, Jacques Kallis and Mark Boucher. I was privileged to be their teammate.

Graeme – or 'Biff', as he became known – made his Test debut against Australia at Newlands on 8 March 2002, and played his last Test 12 years later, almost to the day, against the same opponents at the same venue. In his 117 Tests, he scored 9 265 runs at an average of 48.25 and, in 197 one-day internationals, he scored 6 989 runs at an average of 37.98.

He was appointed Test captain at the age of only 23, asked to inspire a new side, and he proceeded to lead his country in no fewer than 109 Test matches, many more than anyone else in the history of the game, with Allan Border, of Australia, second on 93 and Stephen Fleming, of New Zealand, third on 80.

Of all Graeme's statistics, perhaps the most telling is that he scored 27 Test centuries and, whenever he reached three figures, the Proteas simply did not lose the Test. At Lord's and at Edgbaston in 2003, and again at Edgbaston and at Perth in 2008, he produced magnificent epic innings that effectively won the match.

I respected him because he was tough and uncompromising, because he believed in what he said and did, and because he backed his words with actions. Through the sheer force of his physical presence and personality, he transformed South Africa from talented underperformers